

CINEMA ▼

Just for Laughs

RAJKUMMAR RAO brings his full arsenal of mannerisms to the romcom *Bhool Chuk Maaf*

It isn't just the protagonist of *Bhool Chuk Maaf*, Bollywood as a whole seems to be trapped in a time loop. The cow-belt comedy of manners, of which *Khosla Ka Ghosla* is a distant progenitor and *Bareilly Ki Barfi* the modern instigator, simply won't disappear.

Rajkummar Rao, who headlined *Bareilly...*, leads *Bhool Chuk Maaf* as a man doomed to live out a single day on repeat until he figures out where he went wrong. Like his character Ranjan, Rao is also trapped in the consequences of his actions: being excellent in this sort of broad North Indian comedy.

Seema Pahwa plays Ranjan's mother, while Sanjay Mishra is Bhagwan, the kind of role for which Pankaj Tripathi is always the first choice, but he was possibly busy with *Criminal Justice*. Wamiqa Gabbi plays Titli, who is perpetually mad at her boyfriend Ranjan. The conflict: a no-good loser Ranjan has to secure a job in two months before he can marry Titli. Using Bhagwan, a fixer, Ranjan lands the job. But he finds himself trapped in the day before his wedding date, initially frustrated and, later, trying to understand what character deficiency led to this. Ergo: *Groundhog Day* set in Varanasi. Rao, an immaculate actor, is the film's prime charm, and his arsenal of mannerisms manages to find new ways to tickle your imagination. ■

–Devarsi Ghosh

In this desi version of *Groundhog Day*, Rao's character is left reliving the same day again and again



Stolen

Two brothers from the city (Abhishek Banerjee and Shubham Vardhan) are accused of being child kidnappers in this relentless chase thriller with heartstopping action sequences. Karan Tejpal's film is based on a 2018 incident in Assam, where a businessman and a musician were beaten to death by a mob after being wrongly accused of kidnapping children. On Amazon Prime Video ■

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DETECTIVE SHERDIL

Diljit Dosanjh stars in this comedy thriller from director Ravi Chhabriya. According to the makers, the Budapest-set film "tells the story of a unique detective tasked with solving a case that is far from ordinary". Coming on Zee5. ■

